

Guess where your colleague was at 5:30 A.M. this morning? I was boarding an early-bird flight. Although the plane had room for more than a hundred passengers, only about twenty people were on board. Soon after I sat down, we were told there was fog over the destination and that there would be another famous “short delay.” As I stood up, the woman (I’ll call her Laura) sitting in front of me also stood up. I mentioned to her that I was displeased about having to get up so early to make this flight. She responded that she had been flying all night and still had one more leg in her flight.

I asked Laura why she was traveling at night. She replied that it was a lot more economical to do so. What I found out shortly thereafter was that this woman did not have to fly via a highly discounted ticket. She, in fact, was affluent, but she was also very frugal. What was the purpose of Laura’s travel? She was en route to a conference of real estate executives, where she was to receive the Real Estate Executive of the Year award. I then asked her how she first became involved in the real estate profession. Laura replied, “Out of necessity.”

Laura told me that one morning she found a note from her husband on the kitchen table. Allow me to quote the contents:

Dear Laura,
I’m in love with my secretary. My attorney will fill you in on the details. Wish you and the children good luck.

How did Laura, a housewife with three small children, respond to this information? She was determined not to return to her old job as a high school teacher. Nor would she ever ask her well-to-do parents for economic support. She had grown up in an environment that nurtured independence and discipline. She wondered what she could do with undergraduate and master’s degrees in English literature. She discovered that people with her educational background were in great supply and reasoned that her income from her teaching, editing, and writing jobs were not likely to be enough to support her family’s current lifestyle. Thereupon, Laura discussed various employment opportunities with several enlightened business owners in the community. After these discussions, she decided to try the field of real estate sales. During her first four months, she earned more selling real estate than she did in her best year teaching English.